

Chapter 6

Political responsibility

Many philosophers have lamented philosophy's inability to account for responsibility under the conditions of globalized, advanced capitalism. Hans Jonas pointed out back in 1984 that traditional theories of ethics and moral responsibility were becoming anachronistic.¹

Modern technology has introduced actions of such novel scale, objects, and consequences that the framework of former ethics can no longer contain them ... To be sure, the old prescriptions of the 'neighbor' ethics – of justice, charity, honesty, and so on – still hold in their intimate immediacy for the nearest, day-by-day sphere of human interaction. But this sphere is overshadowed by a growing realm of collective action where doer, deed, and effect are no longer the same as they were in the proximate sphere, and which by the enormity of its powers forces upon ethics a new dimension of responsibility never dreamed of before.²

Other philosophers also believed that traditional conceptions of responsibility were fundamentally challenged by the new circumstances of the late twentieth century. John Ladd responded to the Bhopal explosion of 1984 – at that point, the biggest industrial disaster in history – that 'the adherence by most philosophers to a narrow, legalistic notion of responsibility ... has rendered meaningful discourse about moral responsibility in contexts like the Bhopal disaster impossible, if not incoherent'.³ Samuel Scheffler argued that 'restrictive' theories of moral responsibility, which focus on small-scale, interpersonal interactions, are deeply entrenched in our psyche and practices but are invalid in the context of modern science, technology, communication, travel and economic and political interdependence. While consequentialists have a response – holding individuals responsible for all the possible outcomes of their actions across the whole world – this is not internalizable by most people. He concludes, 'the net effects of these developments may be, not to encourage the substitution of a non-restrictive conception of responsibility for more restrictive ideas, but rather to leave our thinking about responsibility in some disarray'.⁴ Young thought that Scheffler had 'identified a key problem in contemporary moral theory and practice',⁵ but she disagreed that our ethics are left in disarray. Instead, she argued that 'we need a plausible way of conceiving responsibility that connects individual agency to structural processes'.⁶ She aimed to work towards this with her conception of political responsibility.⁷

In the [previous chapter](#), I argued that a person can be held morally blameworthy when they intentionally violate a moral obligation. When it comes to structural injustice, the lack of intent and the lack of direct causal connection means that holding each other blameworthy for

structural injustice is inappropriate; individuals' contributions to structural injustice are inadvertent or the product of social duress and therefore excused. This does not deny the fact that there is injustice that needs to be acknowledged and remedied; rather, it shows that the traditional frameworks of moral responsibility are not equipped to deal with responsibility for structural injustice. These traditional frameworks, however, are only one part of a much bigger picture. In this bigger picture, we contribute to the harming of social groups, or masses of distant people, or to the background structural injustice that disadvantages certain groups and privileges others; but we contribute unintentionally and in a causally indirect or negligible way. Nonetheless, we are somehow connected to and involved in this harm. As Young writes,

If social philosophy assumes that intended and deliberate action is the primary focus of moral judgment, it risks ignoring or even excusing some of the most important sources of oppression.⁸

Young thought it essential to create a supplementary framework of responsibility that can account for responsibility for structural injustice. This is what she aimed to do with her 'social connection model' of responsibility.⁹ On the social connection model, individuals share *political* responsibility for structural injustice they are connected to. This political responsibility is nonblameworthy – individuals can be criticized but not blamed for structural injustice or for failing to act on political responsibility or doing so in an inappropriate way.¹⁰ The responsibility is shared among everyone connected to structural injustice, instead of isolating individuals or groups for blame or recrimination. Political responsibility is forward-looking – it aims to overcome structural injustice, not to attach blame for one-off actions or to reckon debts. And it can only be discharged through collective action.

This new conception of responsibility has generated a lot of philosophical attention and critique. Critics argue it is too vague: what does political responsibility actually entail?¹¹ They also claim that it is non-motivating: why would anyone act on this responsibility if they are not blamed for structural injustice, nor blamed for failing to act on political responsibility?¹² Some philosophers and political theorists have sought to expand traditional conceptions of moral responsibility,¹³ or to find new, innovative approaches to moral responsibility or complicity, to explain ordinary individuals' moral responsibility for structural injustice or to correct for Young's perceived mistakes.¹⁴ But I think that Young, and the other theorists mentioned above, are right. It is legitimate to continue using the traditional models of moral and legal responsibility for their intended purposes. But our world has changed, and instead of trying to reshape or modify existing models of responsibility, it makes sense to rethink it anew. As Young puts it, 'What we should seek is not a variation on a weaker form of liability, but rather a different conception of responsibility altogether.'¹⁵ This makes even more sense when the arguments of this book are taken into account. I have suggested, using a critical realist social ontology, that structural elaboration is the unintended outcome of the actions of all the agents in a given time; the resulting structures are unpredictable and unintended. In other words, agents do not control what the structural framework will look like in the future. Moreover, to the extent that any agents do have any control over this, or perhaps more plausibly 'influence' over this, they are powerful corporate agents like multinational corporations or states, not ordinary individuals acting alone. Powerful agents have more of a chance of getting what they want, either maintaining structures as they are or creating new structures that benefit them. In light of this, seeking to blame ordinary individuals *for the structures* is nonsensical.

In this chapter, I want to defend the concept of political responsibility as a new way of thinking about responsibility for structural injustice, but I take a different perspective on it to Young. First, I outline three different ways of conceiving of political responsibility: Arendt's conception, which I argue is a *virtú* conception; *virtue* conceptions, including socially conscious consumerism and the role-ideal model of responsibility; and Young's conception, which is an ambiguous combination of the *virtú* and *virtue* approaches.¹⁶ In the second part of the chapter, I outline a new conception of political responsibility borrowing Arendt's concept of a 'political virtue'. I argue that political responsibility entails the responsibility to develop the capacity for political solidarity, because it is only through acting in solidarity with others that structural injustice can be overcome.

Political responsibility as *virtú*

Arendt made the distinction between legal, moral and political responsibility in response to Joel Feinberg's essay 'Collective Responsibility'. Feinberg argued that 'Guilt consists in the intentional transgression of a prohibition.'¹⁷ Thus, '*there can be no such thing as vicarious guilt*'.¹⁸ Only the individual who intentionally transgressed a prohibition (be it legal or moral) can be said to be 'guilty' and should 'pay for his sins'.¹⁹ Arendt agrees with Feinberg that legal and moral standards 'always relate to the person and what the person has done'.²⁰ But this posed a problem. Arendt wanted to understand what kind of responsibility 'ordinary Germans' bore for the Holocaust. Because legal and moral responsibility depend on personal responsibility, Arendt believed individuals were not legally nor morally responsible, unless they themselves committed a crime. So in what way can these others be said to have been responsible?

According to Arendt, Feinberg assumes that all issues can be subjected to **moral or legal judgments**, rendering political issues no more than a 'special case' that can be judged according to these same standards. She argues that the rise of Christianity has imposed a hierarchy of values: the strictest standards are moral, and then legal standards are next, with 'customs and manners' coming in last.²¹ Arendt aims to rehabilitate the concept of 'political responsibility' as an equally important and distinct kind of responsibility; it is a collective responsibility shared by citizens.

There are important practical reasons for clarifying the roles of legal, moral and political responsibility. For Arendt, the aim of legal responsibility is clear; it exists to protect the political community. When assigning legal responsibility, she thinks that 'it is irrelevant who is better off, the wrongdoer or the wrong-sufferer. As citizens we must prevent wrongdoing since the world we all share, wrongdoer, wrong-sufferer, and spectator, is at stake; the City has been wronged.'²² The idea that legal responsibility should protect the political community is not particularly controversial. H. L. A. Hart has a similar understanding of the function of the law: we punish 'to protect society from the harm that crime does and not to pay back the harm that they have done'.²³ Arendt's conception of moral responsibility, by contrast, is highly idiosyncratic.

Arendt considers moral responsibility to be self-regarding. She claims that the most influential moral principles are self-referential – 'love thy neighbour as *thyself*', 'Don't do unto others what you don't want to be done to *yourself*' and Kant's maxim, 'Act in such a way that

the maxim of your action can become a general law for all intelligible beings.²⁴ All of these rules, she writes, 'take as their standard the Self and hence the intercourse of man with himself'.²⁵ Retaining moral integrity involves living according to Socrates' advice: 'It is better to suffer wrong than to do wrong.'²⁶ It is worse to do wrong because a person is in constant dialogue with oneself; they are 'two-in-one'.²⁷ She interprets Socrates as implying that 'If I disagree with other people, I can walk away; but I cannot walk away from myself, and therefore I better first try to be in agreement with myself before I take all others into consideration.'²⁸ The ability to think for oneself and judge oneself is a non-technical, pre-philosophic ability, which all people possess, and is practised in solitude.²⁹ The moral person is the person who learns to think for themselves.

We tend to think that morality imposes a set of obligations, as does the law; but Arendt claims that 'the problem of making moral propositions obligatory has plagued moral philosophy since its beginning with Socrates'.³⁰ This is because, unlike with legal responsibility, moral responsibility imposes no real-world sanctions, and the threat of 'future rewards and punishments' in the afterlife is no longer a plausible philosophical foundation, nor a motivation for moral action for many individuals.³¹ Arendt also rejects thinking about morality in terms of obligations because she claims that one set of obligations can easily be exchanged for another. This is how she interprets the collapse of morality in Nazi Germany, where morality 'stood revealed in the original meaning of the word, as a set of *mores*, of customs and manners, which could be exchanged for another set with no more trouble than it would take to change the table manners of a whole people'.³² Persons who hold fast to moral principles are not to be trusted, because they accept rules that are given to them; it is 'the doubters and skeptics' who will constantly ask themselves whether they can live with what they are doing.³³

Arendt's account of moral responsibility poses many problems. Peter Steinberger considers it nihilistic, creating 'a certain kind of intellectual anarchy' by undermining our existing categories.³⁴ Whatever the validity of Arendt's position on moral responsibility, we need to understand it to consider Arendtian political responsibility. For Arendt, 'In the center of moral considerations of human conduct stands the self; in the centre of political considerations of conduct stands the world.'³⁵ The 'world' means something specific to Arendt; the world is the public sphere which enables individuals to voice their plural perspectives on common affairs (plurality) and provides a space for enacting new beginnings (natality). Arendt likens the world to a table – it separates individuals from each other yet allows them to communicate about common themes and to consider common concerns from each other's point of view.³⁶ The world precedes our birth and outlasts our death.³⁷ It must be maintained in order that a space in which individuals can communicate continues to exist: 'If the world is to contain a public space, it cannot be erected for one generation and planned for the living only; it must transcend the life-span of mortal men.'³⁸

What Arendt hoped to encourage by identifying the concept of political responsibility was that all individuals would take up their responsibility for the maintenance of the world. The end of the world is when the common world is seen from one perspective, which presents itself as the *only* perspective.³⁹ Many people in Nazi Germany abdicated their political responsibility, allowing the evil of totalitarianism to take its place: dictators put their faith in absolutist ideologies that preached the inevitable outcomes of human history, people like

Why is a "nonpolitical Jew" different from any other citizen (other associations/base humanity?)

Eichmann reduced themselves to 'cogs in the machine' who existed to obey orders, and more controversially, 'unpolitical Jews' failed to rise up and fight the destruction of the world which would have allowed their viewpoints to be heard.⁴⁰

Political responsibility is distinct from legal responsibility because legal responsibility entails obeying the law, regardless of whether the law is justified. By contrast, political responsibility insists that individuals remain vigilant as to the political system under which they live and ensure that the public/political/plural human world is maintained or reconstituted. Therefore, civil disobedience, breaking the law or revolution may be the *politically responsible* thing to do when the human world is threatened. Political responsibility is also sharply distinguished from moral responsibility in Arendtian thought. The morally responsible person will not do wrong, but the politically responsible person might have to. Arendt often quotes Machiavelli who instructed the Florentine Prince to learn 'how not to be good' – to place the city's needs above his own clean conscience.⁴¹ She writes, 'The political answer to the Socratic proposition would be "What is important in the world is that there be no wrong; suffering wrong and doing wrong are equally bad". Never mind who suffers it; your duty is to prevent it.'⁴² Another difference is that legal and moral responsibility attribute 'guilt' to individuals for particular events and are judged according to the law or the self, respectively, but political 'responsibility' is collective and is judged in relation to the world.

The aim of conceptualizing political responsibility is to find a form of responsibility that does not imply guilt but does imply some sort of responsibility for the world. The aim is not to let ordinary individuals off the hook, but instead to more accurately determine the kind of responsibility they have. Their responsibility is not legal or moral, but it is political. In fact, Arendt argues that claiming that all German citizens of the time were morally responsible for the Nazis' crimes was *harmful* because it obscured where guilt truly lies – with the people who actually committed immoral and illegal acts.

Morally speaking, it is as wrong to feel guilty without having done anything specific as it is to feel free of all guilt if one actually is guilty of something. I have always regarded it as the quintessence of moral confusion that during the postwar period in Germany those who personally were completely innocent assured each other and the world at large how guilty they felt, while very few of the criminals were prepared to admit even the slightest remorse. The result of this spontaneous admission of collective guilt was of course a very effective, though unintended, white-wash of those who *had* done something: as we have already seen, where all are guilty, no one is.⁴³

Arendt was not the only post-war philosopher who thought that attributing guilt to the German people was unwise. Karl Jaspers also made the distinction between 'criminal guilt', which applied to the perpetrators of actual crimes related to the genocide, and 'political liability', which extended to German citizens – a responsibility to pay for the crimes of the regime under which they were governed.⁴⁴ According to Jaspers 'there can be no collective guilt of a people or a group within a people – except for political liability. To pronounce a group criminally, morally or metaphysically guilty is an error akin to the laziness and arrogance of average, uncritical thinking.'⁴⁵ There are similar dynamics at play when individuals express their guilt for structural injustices which are far beyond their control, like poverty, sweatshops and climate change. These individual effusions of guilt distract us from where guilt truly lies – with the agents who have it within their power to do something about it.

Young versus Arendt

Indeed, Young's theory of political responsibility was inspired by Arendt's. But Arendt sought to theorize responsibility for the past crimes of the Holocaust, whereas Young's question is different: 'How shall moral agents think about our responsibility in relation to structural social injustice?'⁴⁶ She writes of Arendt's distinction:

I think that Arendt's effort to distinguish guilt from political responsibility is important and, with several refinements, can contribute to an answer to my starting question. I find highly unsatisfying, however, the meaning she gives to political responsibility.⁴⁷

Young identifies two problems with Arendt's conception of political responsibility. The first is that Arendt ties the conception to membership of a political community. Young writes, 'It is a mystification to say that people bear responsibility simply because they are members of a political community, and not because of anything at all that they have done or not done.'⁴⁸ And Young argues that Arendt is inconsistent on this point. In contrast to the essay 'Collective Responsibility', in the book *Eichmann in Jerusalem*, Arendt discusses the failure to take up political responsibility not only of Germans but also of other nation states and foreign nationals who failed to resist deportations.⁴⁹ Arendt also finds the Danes, who stood up to Hitler and refused to deport Jews, a prime example of taking up political responsibility.⁵⁰ Thus, Young thinks that political responsibility 'derives from something more specific and active than mere membership'.⁵¹ She writes that 'On this interpretation, political responsibility entails *doing* things (and perhaps not doing things), but doing things that indirectly contribute to the enactment of crimes or wrongs.'⁵²

Arendt may have been inconsistent in her use of the concept of political responsibility; nevertheless, there are good reasons within Arendt's overall framework for tying political responsibility to membership of a political community. As discussed above, Arendtian political responsibility is a responsibility to maintain the 'world', which is something that *citizens* share in common. An individual can avoid legal and moral responsibility, but political responsibility is unavoidable. The only way to avoid political responsibility is to leave a political community.⁵³ But for Arendt, leaving a political community means no longer being able to participate in a public sphere, thus engaging in political action and realizing oneself as an individual. Refugees and stateless people are the only persons who can avoid political responsibility, but this 'innocence' is completely undesirable: 'It is precisely this absolute innocence that condemns them to a position outside, as it were, of mankind as a whole.'⁵⁴

Therefore, tying political responsibility to membership is consistent with Arendt's conception of political action in the world.

The second issue Young raises with Arendt's conception of political responsibility is that it is 'backward-looking'. She writes, 'In Arendt's discussion, political responsibility seems to be a concept just as backward-looking as guilt. Her primary case is the Nazi Holocaust, whose events are in the past.'⁵⁵ Young wants to conceptualize political responsibility as 'forward-looking', in contrast to legal and moral responsibility, which are backward-looking. She writes, 'One *has* the responsibility always *now*, in relation to current events and in relation to their future consequences.'⁵⁶ Arendt was asking what responsibility ordinary Germans bore for the Holocaust, so she was necessarily considering responsibility for the past. However,

as I have argued, Arendt's political responsibility is an ongoing responsibility for the world and entails the constitution of a new world should the current world be under threat or corrupted. Thus, even though Arendt is discussing a past event, she is still interested in the responsibility that German citizens had when the event was occurring. In other words, like Young, Arendt is arguing for a 'present and ongoing' responsibility. Her point is that Germans abdicated this responsibility in the past.

The real difference between Young and Arendt, as I see it, is the following. Arendt has a clear explanation of the distinction between moral and political responsibility: the latter is necessarily tied to political community – the world – and is amoral; the former is self-regarding and tied to conscience. Young has a different understanding of moral responsibility compared to Arendt's. Young explicitly cautions against a self-regarding interpretation of morality, claiming that individuals who feel blameworthy for their role in perpetuating injustice are self-centred.⁵⁷ Morality, for Young, concerns others. She writes,

A responsible person tries to deliberate about options before acting, makes choices that seem to be the best for all affected, and worries about how the consequences of his or her action may adversely affect others.⁵⁸

And Young's starting question is different to Arendt's: she asks how we as 'moral agents' should conceptualize our responsibilities for justice, not how we as political agents (or citizens) ought to relate to the world. Thus, Arendt can make a sharp distinction between moral and political responsibility, but Young cannot. Both moral and political responsibility are other-regarding in Young's thought. She needs an explanation, then, as to why political responsibility is not simply a form of moral responsibility. Young hinges this distinction on the backward-lookingness of moral responsibility compared to the forward-lookingness of political responsibility. This way of framing the distinction, however, is questionable; there can be forward-looking varieties of moral responsibility – virtue.

Political responsibility as a virtue

In the [previous chapter](#), I considered and rejected deontological and consequentialist models of moral responsibility for thinking about responsibility for structural injustice; but another way of thinking about it is through the lens of virtue ethics. Many modern versions of virtue ethics take their cues from Aristotle. Most of the Aristotelian virtues are self-regarding. Indeed, Rosalind Hursthouse and Glen Pettigrove argue that modern virtue ethical theories mainly employ three concepts from ancient Greece, which are all self-regarding: 'These are *arête* (excellence or virtue), *phronesis* (practical or moral wisdom) and *eudaimonia* (usually translated as happiness or flourishing).'⁵⁹ However, for Aristotle, there is a fundamental relationship between virtue and politics. The *Nicomachean Ethics* opens by stating that 'The science of human good is politics.'⁶⁰ Individual virtue is other-regarding in the sense that the more virtuous citizens there are, the better the society and political order will be.⁶¹ It is important to cultivate virtue not only for one's sense of integrity and happiness but also to create a just society for all. This way of connecting morality and structural injustice can be seen in the current trend of socially conscious consumerism and Robin Zheng's 'role-ideal model' of responsibility.

Socially conscious consumerism

Socially conscious consumerism is a growing trend and a way that many individuals try to act on their political responsibility for global structural injustice. According to Kate Soper, socially conscious consumers ride bikes, buy organic food and fair trade, and opt for environmental goods and services, promoting a new way of thinking about the 'politics of consumption' and rejecting the negative by-products of our industrialized, polluting and materialistic way of life.⁶² While citizen-consumers are in a minority, Soper views them as practicing an 'avant-garde consumer ethic', which, if it were implemented by more and more people, could lead to sustainable development and altruistically motivated consumption in the Global North and South.⁶³ Soper argues that the 'citizen-consumer' is not necessarily an activist but someone who feels that their potential for living the good life has been compromised by the environmental degradation and fast consumption practices of contemporary life.⁶⁴ In other words, their capacity for happiness or flourishing – *eudaimonia* – has been compromised by globalized neoliberal capitalism.

Michele Micheletti argues that this brand of virtue ethics has emerged because of the collapse of traditional categories of public and private, economy and government. In the advanced capitalist, globalized economy, government is slow to respond to global problems created by mass consumption, and corporations are often more powerful than governments. These conditions have generated a new virtue ethics, which emphasizes modern versions of traditional Aristotelian virtues, especially empathy, social justice and solidarity, and also patience (i.e. acknowledging that change will be slow and incremental); knowledge (a kind of enlightened self-interest about consumption); and a meta-virtue of wisdom, which is needed to decide how and when to act, and in what way, within the politicized global economy. She argues that 'Democratic political consumerism is a virtue-practicing activity. As such, it is an example of *phronesis*: virtues in action in everyday settings.'⁶⁵

Through empirical research, Micheletti has found that socially conscious consumerism is having an impact. It is too early to assess how much of an impact, but it does have a range of benefits.⁶⁶ It gives, what she calls, 'simple folks' a tool for challenging corporations. It makes up for the weakness of traditional political institutions in dealing with globalized economic injustice. It is used in underdeveloped democracies – for example, boycotting Shell in Nigeria. It has revitalized established political bodies like NGOs and trade unions and increased their negotiating strength. And it is often used as a complement to other forms of civic engagement, not as an end in itself. Furthermore, socially conscious consumerism builds bridges between diverse organizations that come together to work on single-issue topics. For example, the Forest Stewardship Certification (FSC) labelling scheme brought together Indigenous groups, environmental groups, forest owners and furniture makers, who all had different public or private motives for preserving forests, but who were able to work together to create a successful campaign.⁶⁷

Lucy Atkinson interviewed socially conscious consumers and found that they were generally motivated by an implicit conception of virtue ethics. They were concerned with 'being a good person', living a good life or a sense of personal integrity or authenticity:⁶⁸ in other words, capturing *arête* (virtue) and *eudaimonia* (flourishing). Rather than being purely selfish, however, Atkinson notes how they were practising a new kind of citizenship – one that merged private attitudes and behaviour with public goods. She writes, 'Among socially

conscious consumers, marketplace behaviors offer a viable and meaningful way to connect their private concerns with concerns for their community, both near and distant. It is by attending to their private, individual concerns that consumers address moral and ethical issues at the collective level.⁶⁹

Socially conscious consumerism is an understandable response to the moral quandaries imposed upon individuals by globalized advanced capitalism. The literature stresses the intricacy of this response and the necessary integration of private and public concerns and rationales. As Micheletti points out, political consumerism is *one* strategy for challenging consumption and production practices.⁷⁰ There are other strategies, which usually combine with socially conscious consumption. It is also not generally lauded as a panacea for global structural injustice. As Soper puts it, to practice socially conscious consumerism 'is to acknowledge how minimal one's power is as an individual consumer – and then to use it nonetheless'.⁷¹

Despite having some attractive features, understanding political responsibility as a private consumerist virtue is not the right approach. If political responsibility is private virtue, it implies that good people cultivate and practice this virtue; thus, presumably, bad people don't. As Hursthouse and Pettigrove argue, 'The concept of a virtue is the concept of something that makes its possessor good: a virtuous person is a morally good, excellent or admirable person who acts and feels as she should.'⁷² The literature on socially conscious consumerism shows that these consumers tend to be middle-class, well-educated and white, and often women.⁷³ They have the time and resources to be able to think about their consumption practices, spend more time shopping and spend more money on products, whereas other social groups are not in the same position. There is something troubling about positioning this group as the 'avant garde of contemporary ethics', as 'good' people in contrast to the 'bad' or 'less good' people who don't engage in these practices. There is a danger of reproducing 'class and gender stereotypes about which sorts of people are susceptible to a relative lack of proper virtue'.⁷⁴

Furthermore, socially conscious consumerism individualizes the political and could even undermine collective action. As W. Lance Bennett argues, it is 'less like conventional social movements with leaders, organizations, and collective identity frames than ... *individualized collective action* where large numbers of people join in loosely coordinated activities centered on more personal emotional identifications and rationales'.⁷⁵ The problem is that 'the individualized orientation of the citizen-consumer further undermines the appeal of adopting collective identifications with party, ideology, or conventional movements'.⁷⁶ Socially conscious consumption could also undermine the generation of more radical proposals aimed at fundamentally challenging the global capitalist economy. It is an easy way out, providing a momentary salve for liberal guilt without threatening the privilege of consumers in the Global North. As Andrew Brooks puts it, 'Liberal-minded citizens in the global North can indulge in their consumption habits without calling for large-scale structural changes that could threaten their own privileged status in global society'.⁷⁷ Finally, empirical research suggests that despite having good intentions, ethical consumers 'rarely' purchase ethical products; there is an 'intentions-behaviour gap' created by environmental factors, such as time pressure, competing ethical demands and the accessibility of cheaper alternatives.⁷⁸

The role-ideal model of responsibility

Robin Zheng does not draw on Aristotelian virtues, but instead highlights the moral responsibility individuals bear to perform their social roles well. Zheng argues that responsibility for structural injustice is grounded in our existing social roles because '*roles are the site where structure meets agency*'.⁷⁹ All agents fulfil various social roles, such as parent or professional of some sort. In performing their social roles, they reproduce social structures. So instead of arguing that individuals bear responsibility for structural injustice by virtue of their connection to it, as Young argues, Zheng argues they bear responsibility because they reproduce it through performance of social roles. Drawing on the sociological theory of structural-functionalism, she argues that society is a '*boundary-maintaining system*' – if people deviate too far from their social roles, the system will restore order.⁸⁰

However, social roles are necessarily open to interpretation. This is an insight from another sociological theory, symbolic interactionism, which highlights that social structures are built from interpersonal interactions that are constantly re-negotiated by individuals rethinking what their social roles entail. What makes a good parent or a good teacher depends on each individual's values, abilities and experiences. Thus, individuals can define their own 'role-ideal'.⁸¹ And they can define their role-ideal for all the various social roles in their lives. The role-ideal model of responsibility posits that 'structural transformation is made possible when all individuals through-out the entire system *push the boundaries of their social roles*'.⁸² The pressure of individuals pushing the boundaries of their social roles can create incremental change or eventually result in 'ruptural changes'.⁸³ Individuals must continually push their social roles 'so as to bring about the conditions of possibility for transformative change'.⁸⁴ Zheng argues that individuals are already committed to this because they are committed to living up to the role-ideals of their social roles, and good role-ideals aim at structural transformation. Zheng argues that this model of responsibility is more actionable than Young's, because individuals are already expected to perform their social roles well and will face sanctions if they don't. She gives the example of a teacher asked to diversify a curriculum.⁸⁵ If the teacher fails to do it, she will be sanctioned; not only is she expected to improve as a teacher, but she is also expected to push her social role in such a way that contributes to structural transformation.

Zheng tries to push the approach in a more political direction than socially conscious consumerism by emphasizing that individuals should push their social roles to enable transformative structural change. But she underestimates the fact that the kinds of activities she notes as pushing for justice – diversifying curricula, using gender-neutral language and so on – have been borne out of social movements, not out of individuals acting alone. It is a history of collective action that has paved the way for individuals to incorporate these sorts of activities into their daily social roles. Furthermore, she assumes that individuals designing their role-ideals will adopt an intersectional feminist theory of justice and that this will be supported by the institutions they work or participate in. However, subscriptions to this way of thinking about justice are not mainstream. Many people will design their role-ideal in a different way to what Zheng would envision as a good role-ideal. For example, take a cis-white, heterosexual man who works in a global garment corporation.⁸⁶ He is a libertarian, so he thinks that sweatshops provide jobs to workers who want and need them. He thinks that being a good employee involves maximizing profits and being accountable to shareholders.

He thinks that he is performing his role well. Zheng wants to disagree because he's failing to challenge the intersectional exploitation of sweatshop labour. But he can simply disagree. Even after debating with others, he can hold fast to his capitalist-libertarian theory of justice. He can continue to promote his theory of justice, which will have very different outcomes to the ones Zheng wants. Moreover, the company he works for fully endorses his way of thinking about justice, not an intersectional-leftist-feminist perspective. This company, therefore, is not going to punish him for not pushing his social role in the direction of transformative structural change. In fact, the vast majority of people in the workforce, who are working for private companies, are not going to be encouraged to push their social roles (at least in the workplace) in the direction of transformative structural change because this is not in the interests of private businesses; they might actually be punished for doing so. This can also be the case in public sector institutions, who ostensibly have an agenda more aligned with social justice.⁸⁷

Ultimately, my main worry about virtue-ethical approaches to responsibility for structural injustice is that they are individualized and privatized and, therefore, play into pre-existing neoliberal ideals about responsibility. In his essay 'Good for Nothing', Mark Fisher argues that 'responsibilisation' is the greatest ideological success of neoliberal capitalism. He writes, 'Each individual member of the subordinate class is encouraged into feeling that their poverty, lack of opportunities, or unemployment, is their fault and their fault alone. Individuals will blame themselves rather than social structures, which in any case they have been induced into believing do not really exist (they are just excuses, called upon by the weak).'⁸⁸

A virtue understanding of political responsibility plays into this narrative. It implies that there is an ethical imperative upon the individual to work on one's character or social roles to be able to overcome structural injustices. It places an unreasonable ethical burden on the individual to counteract forces that are beyond their control and suggests that they are a bad person if they fail to do so.

Chandra Talpade Mohanty locates feminist practice at three levels: daily life, collective action in groups, and theory and pedagogy.⁸⁹ Zheng and socially conscious consumers are engaging in the third level (theory and pedagogy) and give us an account of the first level (action in our daily lives), but they don't tell us much about the second level – collective action. That is missing from their accounts, when in fact it is the precondition for their approaches. Collective action is something Young wanted to focus on, which brings us to Young's theory of political responsibility.

Youngian political responsibility

Young started out by asking what responsibility moral agents bear for structural injustice. Given the limitations of the liability model of responsibility in regard to structural injustice, she argues that agents are not morally responsible for it, but they are politically responsible. Youngian political responsibility, I suggest, is an ambiguous combination of Arendtian political responsibility, or *virtú*, and moral virtue.

Young grounds political responsibility in 'connection' to structural injustice. While the meaning of connection is unclear – sometimes she refers to causal connection (contribution, participation), sometimes dependence on structural injustice and sometimes existence within unjust structures – I believe connection refers to reproduction of unjust structures through

action.⁹⁰ Young understands political responsibility as having five features: it is not isolating, it judges background conditions, it is more forward-looking than backward-looking, it is a shared responsibility and it is discharged only through collective action.⁹¹ It is the element of collective action that gives this responsibility its political flavour. She writes,

Thus we can come around to Arendt's idea that this is a specifically *political* responsibility, as distinct from privately moral or juridical. Taking responsibility for structural injustice under this model involves joining with others to organize collective action to reform the structures. Most fundamentally, what I mean by 'politics' here is public communicative engagement with others for the sake of organizing our relationships and coordinating our actions most justly.⁹²

Youngian political responsibility, therefore, wants to keep some aspects of Arendtian *virtú* – the emphasis on collective responsibility, the need for political action and willingness to endorse radical change. But she also wants to incorporate aspects of the moral approaches. She is considering how 'moral agents' should respond to structural injustice and what 'responsible' individuals should do (meaning people who consider others). In fact, there are good grounds for understanding Young's conception of political responsibility as a virtue. Political responsibility, as Young conceives of it, shares at least six features with moral virtues.

First, virtues are not acquired through having done or not done a specific act in the past. Instead, **a virtue is a disposition** which the moral individual has an ongoing responsibility to cultivate. The orientation of virtue is forward-looking. Second, tying political responsibility to 'justice' – a moral category – rather than the 'world' – a political and contingent circumstance – suggests that it falls into the category of virtue rather than *virtù*. Youngian political responsibility is a *forward-looking* responsibility for *justice*. Third, political responsibility involves engaging in collective action, but the first steps are acquiring knowledge of structural injustice, listening to the claims of victims and encouraging others to act with you;⁹³ in other words 'being' a conscious and engaged, politically responsible person. The sense of 'responsible' is thus different from when we talk about whether or not an agent is causally responsible for a harm that has occurred or is occurring. Young acknowledges that political responsibility draws on the idea of *role responsibility*,⁹⁴ a form of responsibility often associated with virtue ethics. It involves assuming an ongoing role as a politically responsible actor and being responsible within that role.

Fourth, Young's conception of political responsibility is criticized for being too vague, for failing to provide action-guidance.⁹⁵ But the vagueness of political responsibility is deliberate. This is because Young argues that it is *discretionary*, and it is open for individuals to decide how to act on their political responsibility depending on their social position and on how much power, privilege, interest or collective ability they have in relation to a particular structural injustice.⁹⁶ Virtue ethics is often criticized along the same lines – that it is 'unable to provide action-guidance'.⁹⁷ But virtue ethics is not in the business of telling people what to do; instead, it encourages individuals to develop the moral character required to figure out what to do.⁹⁸ So, fifth, we could argue that just as with other kinds of virtue, political responsibility requires the cultivation of *practical wisdom* (*phronesis*). Practical wisdom develops with experience. The person who has developed practical wisdom knows how to discern the relevant features of a situation and how to act in the most responsible way – that

is, the best for all concerned.⁹⁹ As Julia Annas puts it, virtue ethics 'is not a theory which tells us what to do ... we neither have nor should want any such thing. Rather, it guides us by improving the practical reasoning with which we act.'¹⁰⁰

Sixth, Young argues that individuals should not be blamed for failing to act on their political responsibility. But we could, as with virtues, avoid the use of the deontic terms right and wrong and discuss political responsibility in *axiological* terms – good and bad, better or worse.¹⁰¹ Say a person lacks courage; it's not blameworthy that they failed to display courage in a particular situation, but they can work on and improve their moral character by recognizing this weakness and developing it for the future. Similarly, Young writes that 'we can and should be *criticized* for not taking action, not taking enough action, taking ineffective action, or taking action that is counterproductive'.¹⁰² As with other virtues, criticism without blame can lead to a person working on that virtue.¹⁰³

Thus, there is a compelling case to be made that political responsibility is a moral virtue. However, there are reasons for thinking that Young would not have endorsed either of the virtue conceptions of political responsibility presented here. Young's name comes up a lot in the socially conscious consumerism literature. Her theory of individualized responsibility taking is seen as an inspiration, lending theoretical credibility to the concept.¹⁰⁴ However, I'm not convinced that Young would endorse this approach. One of the reasons Young adopted a distinct conception of political responsibility over some version of moral responsibility is because she thinks that ordinary individuals who admit that they are to blame for their role in perpetuating injustice 'become more focused on themselves, their past actions, the state of their souls and their character, than on the structures that require change'.¹⁰⁵ This 'self-indulgence' is a distraction from the real task of getting involved in collective political action for change.¹⁰⁶ The empirical evidence shows that while thinking about the wider social benefits of their behaviour, socially conscious consumers *are* focused on the states of their soul or their character, which Young actively discredits. Even if socially conscious consumption is one strategy among many, and is other-regarding and publicly minded, it is nevertheless concerned with moral character and the good life. The *eudaimonia* aspect of this approach makes it an unsuitable candidate to fill in the blank of what Youngian political responsibility refers to.

Zheng takes Young as her starting point, but she also wants to create a new model of responsibility. Young's approach differs in at least two respects. First, Young drew on the concept of role responsibility to think about political responsibility, but Young pointed out that working within existing roles might be part of the problem. There are times when dismantling old roles and creating new ones is what's called for.¹⁰⁷ Second, Zheng's is an explicitly moral theory about the appropriate behaviour of individuals in social roles. But Young wants to de-individualize political responsibility, making it a shared responsibility that demands collective action. Young insists that political responsibility has a political dimension; it involves collective action for change.

So, on the one hand, Youngian political responsibility does appear to be a virtue. On the other, there are strong reasons for thinking she would not endorse the more fully-fleshed-out virtue ethical conceptions of political responsibility. What, then, is Youngian political responsibility? My view is that Youngian political responsibility *is a form of moral responsibility*. As I interpret her, in Young's thought, there are two types of moral responsibility. This is an established view in moral philosophy: moral responsibility can refer to the appropriate

conditions for praise and blame and what it is to be a morally responsible agent. In *Justice for Hedgehogs*, Ronald Dworkin distinguishes between moral responsibility as a virtue and moral responsibility as ‘a relation between people and events’.¹⁰⁸ When we use the term ‘moral responsibility’ in the virtue sense, we are talking about whether ‘someone behaved responsibly’ or whether they are a responsible person.¹⁰⁹ When we talk about moral responsibility in a relational sense, we are interested in whether or not someone ‘is or is not responsible for some event or consequence’.¹¹⁰

Mark Bovens describes the distinction as the difference between active and passive responsibility. Moral responsibility as accountability is a passive, *backward-looking* form of responsibility that asks for an account of what has happened and may involve some form of retribution – ‘The central question is, “Why *did* you do it?”’¹¹¹ Moral responsibility as virtue is an active and *forward-looking* form of moral responsibility; it requires agents to think about preventing future harm – ‘The central question here is: “what *is* to be done?”’¹¹² The relationship between the two forms of moral responsibility – accountability and virtue – is dynamic. Accountability encourages the cultivation of virtue in the future.¹¹³

Similarly, Young has an account of responsible agency, rather than just passive accountability. She thinks that the responsible person takes an active stance towards their responsibility and always considers others. For Young, a ‘responsible person’ deliberates before acting, makes choices in the interests of all who will be affected and worries about the consequences of those actions. Young thinks ‘being responsible’ implies thinking about others, not oneself. Young also has an account of the relationship between backward-looking and forward-looking responsibility. She argues that moral and legal responsibility are ‘primarily backward-looking’¹¹⁴ and acknowledges the forward-looking elements (e.g. deterrence and reform).¹¹⁵ The forward-looking/backward-looking distinction is not a sharp normative dichotomy but a description of how these practices function and interact with each other. This claim makes sense once we understand the two forms of moral responsibility as accountability (primarily backward-looking) impacting on moral responsibility as virtue (forward-looking).

Thus, as I read Young, the theory that there are two models of moral responsibility is implicit in her account. Young thinks there are two forms of moral responsibility in the other-regarding sense.¹¹⁶ First, interactional – do not directly harm others. Directly harming others activates the ‘liability model’ of responsibility; the agent will be held to account. Second, structural – think about whether and how our actions contribute to structural injustice. It is the second form that constitutes ‘political responsibility’. This is an active, or virtue, sense of responsibility. She writes, ‘Just as it is appropriate to distinguish moral judgment about individual interaction from moral judgment about social-structural processes and their effects, it is necessary to distinguish a conception of individual responsibility in relation to each.’¹¹⁷ Therefore, my suggestion is that Youngian ‘political’ responsibility is distinguished from ‘moral’ responsibility as follows: political responsibility is a moral responsibility individuals have towards structures and requires the cultivation of virtue; moral responsibility is a responsibility in relation to direct interactions with others, and it entails ascriptions of praise and blame.

While this seems like a neat solution, Young’s position is more ambiguous than this suggests, for three reasons. First, moral responsibility as virtue can accommodate forward-

lookingness and responsible agency, but it is self-regarding – which Young wants to avoid – and struggles to account for collective action – which Young wants to emphasize.

Second, as Zheng points out, Youngian political responsibility is more about ‘the *unjust outcomes* that are produced by structural processes, and not the moral quality of individual agents’.¹¹⁸ Thus, Zheng claims that Youngian political responsibility is closer to Dworkin’s relational responsibility, or Bovens’s passive responsibility, or the liability model than a virtue theory of responsibility. Young points this out herself when discussing the relationship between her conception of political responsibility and role responsibility. She says that political responsibility draws more on the idea of role responsibility than the liability usage, but it shares with the liability model ‘a reference to the causes of wrongs – here in the form of structural processes that produce injustice’.¹¹⁹

Third, Young was influenced by a range of Continental theories of responsibility – not only Arendt but also the thought of Hans Jonas (as mentioned at the beginning), Jacques Derrida, Emmanuel Levinas and Larry May.¹²⁰ All these thinkers were grappling with something other than the traditional Western theories of moral responsibility with their emphasis on appropriate ascriptions of praise/blame or responsible agency and more with what it means to be existentially responsible for the unjust circumstances into which one is born. While Young ultimately wants to locate the source of political responsibility in action (the reproduction of unjust structures), there is a lingering remainder of responsibility that arises through no fault of one’s own, from simply existing in the circumstances of injustice.

Ultimately, therefore, I think that Young’s conception of political responsibility is somewhat ambiguous. It does not have the clarity of Arendt’s conception, nor the coherence of the virtue-ethical conception. She is grappling with a range of different conceptions of responsibility but leaves the tensions somewhat unresolved. In the next section, therefore, I will offer a potential solution for thinking about political responsibility.¹²¹

Political virtue

In trying to make sense of political responsibility for structural injustice, I suggest we return to Arendt. I have suggested that political responsibility is amoral for Arendt; Arendtian political responsibility is permissive in terms of what individuals are allowed to do in order to preserve the public sphere from the threat of tyranny. But there are limits to this amorality. Because the aim is to preserve the world, Arendt admits two ‘moral precepts’ into politics. These are forgiving and promising.¹²² Forgiving is essential, because action in the world has unknowable consequences. If people are going to be able to continue acting in the world, they need to be able to forgive each other when things go wrong. Promising is essential for similar reasons; we don’t know what’s going to happen next, so promises are the only way to maintain some guarantees and some stability.

These two moral precepts are not the same as private virtues. They are specifically political virtues because they depend upon the presence of others.¹²³ Promising happens in the form of contracts or treaties between agents. Forgiving releases actors from their past mistakes, when they trespassed against others, so that new beginnings are again possible. Arendt argues that these moral precepts do not derive ‘from some supposedly higher faculty

or from experiences outside action's own reach. They arise, on the contrary, directly out of the will to live together with others in the mode of acting and speaking, and thus they are like control mechanisms built into the very faculty to start new and unending processes.'¹²⁴

Young doesn't discuss this, but Arendt's political virtues are relevant to her. Young argues that political responsibility is non-blameworthy: we shouldn't argue about what went on in the past, we shouldn't blame each other for not acting on political responsibility, and we shouldn't blame each other when things go wrong. This sounds a lot like Arendt's moral precept of forgiveness in politics. If we are to work together in collective action, we need to be able to forgive.¹²⁵ Also relevant is promising. For Arendt, 'the force of mutual promise or contract' keeps collectives together to enact new beginnings.¹²⁶ Indeed, Young recognizes the importance of promising to political responsibility in the form of solidarity. She writes,

The sort of solidarity I am invoking is a relationship among many people who recognize and take up a shared responsibility in relation to the social institutions and practices they enact and support, to make them just. This solidarity is an ideal, *a promise*, and an engagement.¹²⁷

Here, I think, is the crux of the matter. My suggestion is that we should understand political responsibility as a *political virtue* and specifically as *political solidarity*. Solidarity is a specifically political virtue because, like promising and forgiving, it depends on the presence of others; there can be no solidarity without people to be in solidarity with. Political solidarity is necessary if individuals are going to engage in the kinds of collective action that could disrupt and overcome structural injustice. Political virtue is the point where politics and morality meet, but it is not the same as private virtue. The virtue conception implied that there is an ethical imperative to work on one's character to counteract structural injustice and had the potential to suggest that an individual is a bad person if they fail to do this. On the political virtue approach, the individual does not have a bad character and is not a bad person if they are not challenging structural injustice through socially conscious consumerism or virtuously fulfilling an existing social role with a view to ameliorating injustice; rather to be a moral person in the context of structural injustice, an agent ought to develop their capacity for political solidarity and then act on it.¹²⁸ Thus, individuals do not have to develop the *right character* to live the good, virtuous life but the *right capacities* to participate in collective action.¹²⁹ In the remainder of this chapter, I explain how political responsibility relates to empowerment, the work individuals must do in order to be politically responsible individuals, and why *political responsibility does not involve blame*.

Individual and collective empowerment

Philosophers in the Western traditions tend to focus on the responsibility of the privileged in relation to 'distant others'.¹³⁰ But one of the most striking aspects of Young's theory of political responsibility was her attempt to counteract this tendency by including everyone connected to structural injustice in shared responsibility for it. Of course, this was not Young's innovation; the responsibility to stand up and resist comes up time and again in the literature from, what Angela Davis calls, The Black Freedom Movement, which encompasses everything from emancipation from slavery, to reconstruction, Civil Rights, struggles against colonialism and critical race theory and practice today.¹³¹

What constitutes a 'victim' of structural injustice? The victims are not powerful in relation to the injustice; they do not have the systemic or dispositional power to effect structural change like large corporations or states. They also don't benefit from the injustice: the opposite is true; the victims are people who are rendered vulnerable to domination or oppression from structural injustice. Victims are structurally situated so as to be powerless in relation to, and rendered vulnerable by, structural injustice – this is why they are victims. However, they are victims only in this narrow sense. Victims are not solely victims; they are also *agents*.¹³²

The desire to absolve victims of political responsibility to stand up for themselves and get involved in movements for justice corresponds to a tendency identified by post-colonial feminists – the tendency to objectify victims. Mohanty argues that the group 'Third world women' are constructed in Western feminist literature, 'as a homogenous, "powerless" group'.¹³³ Categorizing Third World women as inherently powerless victims 'robs them of their historical and political *agency*'.¹³⁴ Victims tend to be seen as non-agents in need of rescue, rather than as agents who can and do engage in acts of resistance. As bell hooks forcefully argues, oppressed people know they are oppressed and are often already engaged in resistance.¹³⁵ She argues that women who are oppressed do not want to think of themselves as victims because they want to focus on what they *can* do. Furthermore, 'Women, even the most oppressed among us, do exercise some power.'¹³⁶

The modes of power discussed so far in this book – episodic, dispositional and structural – and the underlying unjust power relations of domination and oppression, do not take into account the more positive sense of power as empowerment. Amy Allen criticizes Young on precisely this point: 'A fully satisfactory critical theoretical analysis of power needs to be able to highlight **not** only domination or oppression but also individual and collective empowerment and the complex interconnections between these different modalities of power.'¹³⁷

Including an account of empowerment shows how why and how victims can be included in sharing political responsibility. Many transnational women's collectivities have arisen in response to global structural injustices. Hye-Ryoung Kang highlights the Central American Network of Women in Solidarity with Maquila Workers, the Asian Women's Immigrant Advocates, Feminists Against Sweatshops and the East Asia-US-Puerto Rico Women's Network Against Militarism.¹³⁸ Kang argues that by engaging with others who are also experiencing oppression, two mutually reinforcing processes occur.¹³⁹ Through discussion, consciousness is raised and victims are enabled to call their situation injustice – we can call this individual empowerment. And collectivities are more able to broadcast and vocalize justice claims than isolated individuals – collective empowerment. Individual and collective empowerment are co-constitutive: the individual might need the conceptual and normative resources generated by social movements in order to become individually empowered.¹⁴⁰ But, in turn, these social movements emerge because of empowered individuals coming together in large enough numbers to create these resources and to build a critical mass that is taken seriously. Brooke Ackerly assessed the strategies of 125 women's rights activist organizations and found that a core strategy across the board was to develop the self-

advocacy skills of victims: 'These human rights defenders practice the normative value that even those with unsecure freedom can and should exercise their capacity to take political responsibility and should do so in ways that develops others' capacities for doing so.'¹⁴¹

Including the victims in shared responsibility for structural injustice is not tantamount to victim blaming. On the liability model of responsibility, including the victims would be victim blaming because it isolates particular individuals for blame, thereby absolving others.¹⁴² But political responsibility is a shared and non-blameworthy responsibility to cultivate the capacity for political solidarity. An agent does not need to be privileged to develop the capacity for political solidarity; people from all walks of life participate in solidaristic actions all the time. Not including the victims would be to marginalize and objectify them.

The work of solidarity

Individual and collective empowerment depend on solidarity. The victims of structural injustice could be excluded from solidarity, however, depending on how solidarity is understood. Some theorists have expressed concerns over the concept of solidarity on the grounds that it is often exclusionary. Solidarity can be a means to cement existing social, civic or political relations rather than to create new ones. We see this to some extent in Arendt's conception of political responsibility. Taken at face value, if political responsibility is tied to the political community, it would seem to exclude those who are not members of the community. In pre-nineteenth-century conceptions of solidarity, it implied social cohesion, which was particularly pernicious in the colonial context where the imperial metropole was the epicentre of cohesion or in religious traditions in which dissent was suppressed.¹⁴³ From the nineteenth century on, the term shifted to signify group interests and political struggle, in the work of Marx and Engels and Max Weber.¹⁴⁴ This is what we still tend to mean by solidarity. Critics argue, however, that such a meaning continues to promote group unity and, thus, exclusion and the denial of difference, a problem that has particularly plagued feminist movements.

But Jodi Dean argues that while some versions of solidarity are problematic, we should not throw the baby out with the bathwater.¹⁴⁵ Some kinds of solidarity do suffer from exclusion, such as affectional solidarity (solidarity with those to whom we have personal ties) or conventional solidarity (Marxist, religious or identity-based solidarity, which imposes group unity and posits an 'us' versus 'them'). But it is possible to have a conception of solidarity that is respectful of difference. She calls this 'reflective solidarity', which depends on 'openness to difference which lets our disagreements provide the basis for connection'.¹⁴⁶ Reflective solidarity does not assume that a given identity or common interest is sufficient to ground solidarity; instead, 'Reflective solidarity urges that we replace ascribed identities with achieved ones and substitute an enforced commonality of oppression with communities of those who have chosen to work and fight together.'¹⁴⁷

If difference and disagreement are integral components of creating and maintaining solidary relationships, then solidarity is no longer straightforward. As Dean puts it, reflective solidarity 'has to be achieved', and it is 'never easy and always at risk'.¹⁴⁸ Developing the capacity for solidarity involves *work* in order to be willing and able to engage in creating and maintaining relationships across difference. This work will look different depending on the social position of the agent involved. Starting with the *oppressed*, it may involve a process of

introspection and self-recognition prior to or in tandem with engaging in collective action. For instance, Fanon discusses a patient who told him of a dream where he was in a room with white men and realized that he was white too.¹⁴⁹ Fanon argues that the man is suffering from an 'inferiority complex' and that he has to do two things: one is to work on himself to overcome his lack of self-recognition and the other is to struggle against the social structures that generate the complex in the first place.¹⁵⁰ hooks argues, similarly to Fanon, that victims need to reflect on the ways in which they are socialized so that their behaviour perpetuates the status quo.¹⁵¹ But hooks also argues that self-evaluation and self-critique is something that the *privileged* must engage in.¹⁵² This involves unlearning what privileged individuals think they know. For instance, hooks writes of the feminist movement that white women will have demonstrated their political commitment to eliminating racism 'when they work to unlearn racist socialization' before they assume leadership roles, writing theory or working with women of colour.¹⁵³ In other words, privileged individuals need to work on themselves to overcome prejudices, biases or a sense of entitlement.

hooks also argues that the oppressed must participate in emancipatory struggle because of 'the special vantage point our marginality gives us and make use of this perspective to ... envision and create a counter-hegemony'.¹⁵⁴ Young also draws attention to the epistemic insight of the oppressed in understanding their situation and thus being better placed to know what to do about it.¹⁵⁵ But again this raises a corresponding responsibility on the part of the privileged. The privileged cannot rely on the oppressed to educate them about injustice because this amounts to epistemic exploitation.¹⁵⁶ The time, effort and emotional toll it takes to repeatedly explain how oppression manifests itself for any individual or social group is an unfair extraction of labour from the oppressed. As Françoise Vergès writes, white women 'need to understand how tiring it is, always having to educate them about their own history. After all, whole libraries on this topic are available to them. What is holding them back? Why are they waiting to be educated?'¹⁵⁷ So while the oppressed should engage in collective action against structural injustice because of their knowledge of and insight into it, this shouldn't be abused by the privileged as license not to learn about injustice and to expect the oppressed to do all of the intellectual and epistemic labour.

So far, the forms of work I have associated with political virtue are largely introspective, focused on learning or unlearning received views about oneself or others. However, the ultimate goal is to build solidaristic relations with others in order to engage in collective action. José Medina argues that agents need to foster 'resistant imaginations': ways of imagining both at the object level and meta-level. He gives the example of Nazi Germany. Resistant imagination at the object level would be to challenge the stigmatization of Jews, homosexuals, the Roma and Sinti and so on. At the meta-level it means resisting the idea that humanity is divided into inferior and superior races.¹⁵⁸ Medina argues that resistant imagining isn't a solo affair. Engaging with others' resistant imaginings, which may be different to our own, generates 'epistemic friction' and can provide the grounds for radical solidarity. He writes: 'Our social imaginings have to be radically pluralized and opened up to epistemic friction in order to meliorate our social sensibilities and to create or improve relations of solidarity.'¹⁵⁹ With plural social imaginations, social perceptions can be changed, individuals can better perceive others' problems, interests and needs on their own terms and in relation to their own and become invested in them.¹⁶⁰

Young also acknowledged this imperative of solidarity to listen to others. She writes, 'People who understand that they share responsibility in relation to injustice and justice call on one another to answer before a public. The political process consists in the constitution of a public in which members raise problems and issues and demand of one another actions to address them.'¹⁶¹ But, if people are going to work together and genuinely listen to each other, a further form of work that the privileged need to do is to learn how to interact with victims in a spirit of solidarity and respect. hooks highlights the phenomenon of individuals who opportunistically seek legitimacy for their actions, rather than acting with victims in a spirit of solidarity. For example, she argues that white feminists 'condescended' towards black feminists, 'that we were able to participate because they allowed it, even encouraged it; after all, we were needed to legitimate the process. They did not see us as equals. They did not treat us as equals.'¹⁶² To engage in political solidarity means recognizing the oppressed as equal active participants in movements to undermine the injustice that affects them, rather than using them as a means to an end of legitimizing one's own activism.

And as Arendt pointed out, it also means not treating the oppressed as needy people who can be patronized and who 'good' privileged people are trying to help.¹⁶³ Arendt rejected the entrance of emotions like pity into politics, because acting in the interests of the 'good of others' is hubristic and objectifies people, rather than respecting them as equal political participants.¹⁶⁴ She attributes the terror after the French revolution to the entrance of pity into the public sphere, because it rendered *le peuple* as an indistinct mass, rather than recognizing them as separate persons, thereby paving the way for mass violence.¹⁶⁵ As Lawrence Biskowski writes, 'When our actions are inspired by pity or some other emotion, we begin to lose our bearings, precisely because such emotions take no account of, and are harmful to, the "in-between" that separates and relates human beings.'¹⁶⁶ Pity is patronizing and homogenizing, whereas solidarity depends upon respect.¹⁶⁷

A form of work that *all* participants in collective action need to do is to acknowledge that difference and disagreement are necessary components of political organizing. Any sort of shared identity or interest (gender, race or class, for example) is not sufficient to generate solidarity, nor to dilute disagreement. hooks gives the example of a group of students she was working with. Despite some ostensible shared identities or interests, the group as a whole learnt that 'our different experiences often meant that we had different needs, that there was no one strategy or formula for the development of political consciousness. By mapping out various strategies, we affirmed our diversity while working towards solidarity.'¹⁶⁸ Another form of work that all participants have to grapple with is sustaining political solidarity over time. As Sally Scholz points out, sustaining praxis is difficult. Groups can disperse; once a goal has been overcome, individuals with weak commitments might leave and individuals with strong commitments might burn out or lose interest in the group.¹⁶⁹

Thus, being able to engage in political solidarity requires the development of certain skills and capacities. The work involved depends on an agent's social position, which will vary depending on the structural injustice they are seeking to address. Some of the forms of work involved are the following (but this is not exhaustive): unlearning received biases and prejudices, both conscious and unconscious in relation to oneself and others; keeping distance or space between oneself and the others with whom one is working in political solidarity, to avoid patronizing or objectifying them, or using them, rather than engaging with them in terms of mutual respect; developing the capacity to listen to others, and to

acknowledge and accept their different and competing concerns or points of view; fostering a resistant imagination oneself and through communication with others; reflecting on how one's own behaviour reproduces injustice; being responsive to changes in the collective or changes in the circumstances in which the collective is acting; and developing stamina for continuing to engage. These skills and capacities are learned over time, through engaging with others and through trial and error. And, as Medina puts it, 'The tasks of radical solidarity are indeed not easy tasks.'¹⁷⁰ My claim is that political responsibility is the responsibility an individual has to do this work.

Of course, this is not only an individual-level responsibility. Groups also do this work when struggling against structural injustice. In her empirical assessment of women's human rights groups, Ackerly identifies ten core strategic activities.¹⁷¹ We have already seen that these groups develop the self-advocacy skills of individuals and, relatedly, they develop community capacities. Several strategies involve integrating inequality and epistemic lacunae: engaging in intersectional analysis – integrating an understanding of how structural injustice affects differently positioned individuals and groups; making cross-issue connections – for instance women's economic exploitation and domestic violence; analysing external threats and opportunities; assessing internal strengths and weaknesses; and organizational learning. Another group of strategies focus on solidarity: networking, developing potential partnerships, and building bridges with potential stakeholders. These strategies are politically expedient, but sometimes they don't work; however, they all reflect a normative commitment to continuous learning and cultivating solidarity across difference.

Responsibility without blame

Young argues that political responsibility does not involve blame. Many theorists have challenged this particular aspect of political responsibility. Martha Nussbaum famously calls this the 'free pass' objection – if individuals are not blamed for failing to take up political responsibility, then they get a free pass to continue as they are.¹⁷² But distinguishing responsibility from blame is not only possible, it is essential to realizing political responsibility for structural injustice.

Hanna Pickard has developed a conception of 'Responsibility without Blame' in the context of clinical psychiatry, particularly in the treatment of service users with personality disorders. Such people often behave in ways that we ordinarily think of as blameworthy – they bully, manipulate, harm others, self-harm for effect and sometimes commit grave offenses which leads to their hospitalization.¹⁷³ The appropriate stance towards these service users is Responsibility without Blame. This stance enables clinicians to recognize both that these people are agents who have it within their power to behave differently, but also that they have been shaped by histories of adversity, including childhood trauma, abuse, neglect and circumstances like war and poverty. Blaming people for their behaviour 'risks creating feelings of rejection, anger, shame, hopelessness, and desperation ... thereby undermining the possibility that responsibility and accountability may enable learning and change'.¹⁷⁴ But not holding them responsible fails to enable them to make different choices in future by supporting them to learn new skills, improving their capacity for control and enabling them to better recognize their feelings and motivations.¹⁷⁵ This is the 'rescue-blame trap', which clinical practice aims to avoid.¹⁷⁶

Westerners struggle to distinguish between blame and responsibility, Pickard argues, because Western cultures tend to thread the two together. However, they are in fact quite clearly distinct: 'responsibility is about *the other person*, while blame is about us and how *we choose to respond to that person*'.¹⁷⁷ A person is responsible for their actions if they meet the criteria of having done something wrong and they chose to do it. But whether or not they are blamed for that action depends on the response of the people around them. Blame involves holding and displaying negative feelings towards that person, such as anger, resentment or disgust; it involves negative judgments about the person's actions or even their character; and it could involve punitive behaviour like aggression or ostracism.¹⁷⁸ In a clinical context, clinicians are enabled to avoid blaming patients because they have a duty of care towards patients, there are guidelines establishing how to speak to patients, there is a norm of enabling the service user to take responsibility, and clinicians have developed their 'poker face' knowing how to mask their emotions and refrain from acting on them.¹⁷⁹ Most importantly, clinicians learn about and pay attention to the service user's history, enabling them to understand the behaviour in the context of that person's life story.

Pickard argues that the criminal justice system can learn from this insight. In the criminal justice context, similarly to the clinical context, blaming offenders leads to feelings of hopelessness and desperation, which runs counter to the goal of rehabilitating them and reducing crime in future.¹⁸⁰ Instead, we should develop 'an attitude of concern, respect, and compassion for the offender', which 'may do better to help them address their offending behaviour and enable learning and change'.¹⁸¹ If such a stance is possible in contexts where people have committed crimes, why is it not possible in relation to people who are going about their daily lives and inadvertently reproducing structural injustice? Moreover, Arendt and Jaspers argued in favour of political responsibility in the context of the Holocaust – an extreme situation where extended moral responsibility might seem warranted. Structural injustice does not reach these heights. It is mundane and ingrained in the system. As Young puts it,

Structural injustice is not as horrible as systematically perpetrated genocide; I think of it as 'ordinary' injustice. Such injustice must be of concern to us as moral and political agents, precisely because it is more everyday, and often conditions other criminal acts. I find the idea of political responsibility that I have interpreted and developed out of Arendt's texts particularly useful for giving an account of responsibility in relation to structural injustice.¹⁸²

Blame in this context is disproportionate and unfair. But just because we shouldn't blame people does not mean we can no longer recognize them as responsible agents who can take responsibility for their reproduction of unjust structures through their actions. We do not need to know every individual's entire life story in order to do this; we simply need to recognize that they were born into unjust social structures and have been socialized into reproducing these structures. We can also accept that changing unjust social structures is beyond the power of that individual. But we can recognize that every individual can develop the capacity for political solidarity and work with others to try to bring about change. Avoiding blame can be difficult since it is the immediate response of people socialized in Western cultures, but Pickard argues that 'As a first step, and quite generally, we can keep the

distinction between responsibility and blame clearly before our minds, and undertake to challenge our own sense of righteousness and entitlement while cultivating a commitment to treating all people ... with respect, concern and compassion.¹⁸³

But there is an ambiguity in Young's discussion of blame. It is unclear whether agents are not blamed for their reproduction of structural injustice or whether they are not blamed for failure to take up political responsibility. It seems to be both for Young. But other theorists have separated the two. For instance, Catherine Lu does not blame agents for reproduction of structural injustice but does blame them for failure to act on political responsibility.¹⁸⁴ In my view, blame is still inappropriate here. Zheng provides a useful way to think about this. Drawing on an analogy with pedagogy, she distinguishes between summative and formative criticism. Summative criticism is criticism against a benchmark – for example, being graded for an exam. Formative criticism is feedback on how the student is doing, without recourse to a grade. Zheng applies this to 'moral criticism'. A person who knowingly violates a moral obligation would be a candidate for summative criticism, and hence blame. But a person who is lagging behind in their political responsibility would be a candidate for formative criticism, or 'course correction'.¹⁸⁵ They could be reminded that there is more they could be doing and steered in the right direction, rather than scolded and blamed.

I would add that this is especially true when we consider that challenging structural injustice entails engaging in collective action, and engaging in collective action entails developing the capacity for political solidarity, which is a process. As Barrett Emerick argues in relation to our loved ones, we should 'play the long game with someone, and to be with them through their moral development – just as we need others to be with us in ours'.¹⁸⁶ We also need to play the long game in individuals' political development, since we are shaped and socialized in the context of injustice and working to develop ourselves to be effective participants in collective action for justice takes time and will be full of mistakes. Identifying agents as blameworthy or bad plays a minimal role in considerations of political solidarity. Instead, the focus is on working together to achieve the goal of overcoming structural injustice. As Scholz puts it, 'political solidarity requires a concerted effort to work with others to alleviate some oppression or injustice and, given the intransigency of both, blame laying plays a very insignificant part. Instead, members owe each other a continued commitment to the cause that also affects their relationships with each other.'¹⁸⁷

Conclusion

The responsibility that individuals bear for structural injustice is political responsibility, which is a responsibility to develop the capacity for political solidarity and act on it. Political solidarity is the grounds for individual and collective empowerment and will lead to effective collective action. Understanding political responsibility as a specifically political virtue – it arises from the need to work with others, not from character-based virtue – overcomes the dichotomous thinking between morality or politics. As Mohanty puts it, 'solidarity is a political as well as ethical goal'.¹⁸⁸ Or to borrow from Chantal Mouffe, it is an 'ethico-political' concept.¹⁸⁹ The concept of political virtue better captures what is at stake when conceiving of responsibility for structural injustice than the virtue or *virtù* approaches, or Young's ambiguous combination of the two. Political responsibility is the responsibility individuals

bear for unjust social-structural processes, and on my interpretation, it involves the development of the capacity for solidarity in order to be able to participate in collective action for change. Individuals should not be blamed for failing to do this, but rather the fact that we are all born into and shaped by structural injustice should be recognized. Thus, we can take a compassionate approach and steer each other in the right direction, encouraging both individual and collective empowerment.

- ¹ Young opens her 2004 paper with a quote from Jonas: Iris Marion Young, 'Responsibility and Global Labor Justice', *Journal of Political Philosophy* 12, no. 4 (2004): 365. She also cites him on the idea that 'Political responsibility seeks not to reckon debts, but aims rather to bring about results'. Young, 'Responsibility and Global Labor Justice', 379.
- ² Hans Jonas, *The Imperative of Responsibility: In Search of an Ethics for the Technological Age* (London: University of Chicago Press, 1985), 6.
- ³ John Ladd, 'Bhopal: An Essay on Moral Responsibility and Civic Virtue', *Journal of Social Philosophy* 22, no. 1 (1991): 73.
- ⁴ Samuel Scheffler, 'Individual Responsibility in a Global Age', in *Boundaries and Allegiances: Problems of Justice and Responsibility in Liberal Thought* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2001), 46.
- ⁵ Young, 'Responsibility and Global Labor Justice', 374.
- ⁶ Iris Marion Young, 'Political Responsibility and Structural Injustice', *The Lindley Lecture* (University of Kansas, 2003), 8.
- ⁷ Young, 'Responsibility and Global Labor Justice', 8.
- ⁸ Iris Marion Young, *Justice and the Politics of Difference* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1990), 150.
- ⁹ Iris Marion Young, *Responsibility for Justice* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011), 104–13.
- ¹⁰ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 113–22, 144.
- ¹¹ Christian Barry and Kate Macdonald, 'How Should We Conceive of Individual Consumer Responsibility to Address Labour Injustices?', in *Global Justice and International Labour Rights*, ed. Faina Milman-Sivan, Yossi Dahan and Hanna Lerner (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016), 92–118; Robin Zheng, 'What Is My Role in Changing the System? A New Model of Responsibility for Structural Injustice', *Ethical Theory and Moral Practice* 21 (2018): 869–85; Christian Neuhäuser, 'Structural Injustice and the Distribution of Forward-Looking Responsibility', *Midwest Studies in Philosophy* 38 (2014): 232–51; Henning Hahn, 'The Global Consequence of Participatory Responsibility', *Journal of Global Ethics* 5, no. 1 (2009): 43–56.
- ¹² Martha C. Nussbaum, 'Foreword', in *Responsibility for Justice*, ed. Iris Marion Young (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011), ix–xxv; Zheng, 'What Is My Role in Changing the System? A New Model of Responsibility for Structural Injustice'.
- ¹³ Barry and Macdonald, 'How Should We Conceive of Individual Consumer Responsibility to Address Labour Injustices?'
- ¹⁴ Charlotte Knowles, 'Responsibility in Cases of Structural and Personal Complicity: A Phenomenological Analysis', *The Monist* 104 (2021): 224–37; Corwin Aragon and Alison M. Jaggar, 'Agency, Complicity, and the Responsibility to Resist Structural Injustice', *Journal of Social Philosophy* 49, no. 3 (2018): 439–60; Zheng, 'What Is My Role in Changing the System? A New Model of Responsibility for Structural Injustice'; Mara Marin, *Connected by Commitment: Oppression and Our Responsibility to Undermine It* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2017).
- ¹⁵ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 104.
- ¹⁶ The reader might recognize the virtue/virtú distinction from Bonnie Honig, *Political Theory and the Displacement of Politics* (New York: Cornell University Press, 1993). But Honig uses terms differently to me. Honig identifies Kant, Rawls and Sandel as virtue theories, because their theories 'displace conflict, identify politics with administration and treat juridical settlement as the task of politics and political theory'. Whereas Nietzsche and Arendt's *virtù* theories characterize 'politics as a disruptive practice that resists the consolidations and closures of administrative and juridical settlement for the sake of the perpetuity of political contest'. Honig argues that virtue theories of politics, in their quest to settle politics in forms of legal administration, have anti-democratic tendencies. Ultimately, politics will

always involve both settlement and contestation. While I have been inspired by Honig's set-up of the virtue-*virtù* distinction, I am using it in a more literal sense to question whether the specific concept of political responsibility is a virtue, something that is morally praiseworthy and related to character, or a *virtù*, something that is political, responds to changing circumstance and does not have moral goodness at its centre.

¹⁷ Joel Feinberg, 'Collective Responsibility', *Journal of Philosophy* 65, no. 21 (1968): 676.

¹⁸ Feinberg, 'Collective Responsibility', 676.

¹⁹ Feinberg, 'Collective Responsibility', 676.

²⁰ Hannah Arendt, 'Collective Responsibility', in *Responsibility and Judgment*, ed. Jerome Kohn (New York: Schocken Books, 2003), 148.

²¹ Hannah Arendt, 'Thinking and Moral Considerations', in *Responsibility and Judgment*, ed. Jerome Kohn (New York: Schocken Books, 2003), 182.

²² Arendt, 'Thinking and Moral Considerations', 182.

²³ H. L. A. Hart, *Punishment and Responsibility: Essays in the Philosophy of Law*, 2nd edn (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008), 201.

²⁴ Hannah Arendt, 'Some Questions of Moral Philosophy', in *Responsibility and Judgment*, ed. Jerome Kohn (New York: Schocken Books, 2003), 76. Her emphasis.

²⁵ Arendt, 'Some Questions of Moral Philosophy', 76.

²⁶ Arendt, 'Some Questions of Moral Philosophy', 90; Arendt, 'Collective Responsibility', 151.

²⁷ Arendt, 'Some Questions of Moral Philosophy', 92.

²⁸ Arendt, 'Some Questions of Moral Philosophy', 90.

²⁹ Arendt, 'Some Questions of Moral Philosophy', 93.

³⁰ Arendt, 'Some Questions of Moral Philosophy', 72.

³¹ Arendt, 'Collective Responsibility', 153.

³² Hannah Arendt, 'Personal Responsibility under Dictatorship', in *Responsibility and Judgment*, ed. Jerome Kohn (New York: Schocken Books, 2003), 43.

³³ Arendt, 'Personal Responsibility Under Dictatorship', 45.

³⁴ Peter J. Steinberger, 'Hannah Arendt on Judgment', *American Journal of Political Science* 34, no. 3 (1990): 819.

³⁵ Arendt, 'Collective Responsibility', 153.

³⁶ Hannah Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 2nd edn (London: University of Chicago Press, 1998), 52.

³⁷ Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 55; Lawrence J. Biskowski, 'Practical Foundations for Political Judgment: Arendt on Action and World', *Journal of Politics* 55, no. 4 (1993): 879.

³⁸ Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 55.

³⁹ Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 58.

⁴⁰ Margaret Canovan, *Hannah Arendt: A Reinterpretation of Her Political Thought* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994), 52.

⁴¹ For example, Arendt, 'Collective Responsibility', 154; Arendt, 'Some Questions of Moral Philosophy', 80.

⁴² Arendt, 'Collective Responsibility', 153.

⁴³ Arendt, 'Personal Responsibility under Dictatorship', 28.

⁴⁴ Jaspers unhelpfully uses the terms 'political guilt' and 'political liability' interchangeably. But he makes it clear that when liability is 'political' it is different in kind to moral or criminal guilt. He writes:

'Guilt ... is necessarily collective as the political liability of nationals, but not in the same sense as moral and metaphysical, and never as criminal guilt.' Karl Jaspers, *The Question of German Guilt* (New York: Dial Press, 2000), 55–6.

⁴⁵ Jaspers, *The Question of German Guilt*, 36.

⁴⁶ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 75.

⁴⁷ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 79.

⁴⁸ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 79.

⁴⁹ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 87.

⁵⁰ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 90–1.

⁵¹ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 86.

⁵² Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 80.

⁵³ Arendt, 'Collective Responsibility', 150.

⁵⁴ Arendt, 'Collective Responsibility', 150.

⁵⁵ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 92.

⁵⁶ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 92.

⁵⁷ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 118.

⁵⁸ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 25.

⁵⁹ Rosalind Hursthouse and Glen Pettigrove, 'Virtue Ethics', *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2016.

⁶⁰ Aristotle, *The Nicomachean Ethics*, *Oxford World's Classics* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009), 3.

⁶¹ Gisela Striker, 'Aristotle's Ethics as Political Science', in *The Virtuous Life in Greek Ethics*, ed. Burkhard Reis (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006), 140.

⁶² Kate Soper, 'Rethinking the "Good Life": The Consumer as Citizen', *Capitalism, Nature, Socialism* 15, no. 3 (2004): 115.

⁶³ Soper, 'Rethinking the "Good Life"', 114.

⁶⁴ Soper, 'Rethinking the "Good Life"', 112–13.

⁶⁵ Michele Micheletti, *Political Virtue and Shopping* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2003), 150.

⁶⁶ Micheletti, *Political Virtue and Shopping*, 161–4.

⁶⁷ Micheletti, *Political Virtue and Shopping*, 154.

⁶⁸ Lucy Atkinson, 'Buying in to Social Change: How Private Consumption Choices Engender Concern for the Collective', *Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 644, no. 1 (2012): 196–203.

⁶⁹ Atkinson, 'Buying in to Social Change', 192.

⁷⁰ Micheletti, *Political Virtue and Shopping*, 166.

⁷¹ Soper, 'Rethinking the "Good Life"', 115.

⁷² Hursthouse and Pettigrove, 'Virtue Ethics'.

⁷³ Atkinson, 'Buying in to Social Change', 195; Micheletti, *Political Virtue and Shopping*, 157.

⁷⁴ Clive Barnett, Philip Cafaro and Terry Newholm, 'Philosophy and Ethical Consumption', in *The Ethical Consumer*, ed. Rob Harrison, Terry Newholm and Deirdre Shaw (London: Sage, 2005), 8.

⁷⁵ W. Lance Bennett, 'The Personalization of Politics: Political Identity, Social Media, and Changing Patterns of Participation', *Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 644, no. 1 (2012): 26.

⁷⁶ Bennett, 'The Personalization of Politics', 26.

- ⁷⁷ Andrew Brooks, *Clothing Poverty: The Hidden World of Fast Fashion and Second-Hand Clothes* (London: Zed Books, 2015), 216.
- ⁷⁸ Michal J. Carrington, Benjamin A. Neville and Gregory J Whitwell, 'Why Ethical Consumers Don't Walk Their Talk: Towards a Framework for Understanding the Gap between the Ethical Purchase Intentions and Actual Buying Behaviour of Ethically Minded Consumers', *Journal of Business Ethics* 97 (2010): 139–58.
- ⁷⁹ Zheng, 'What Is My Role in Changing the System?', 870.
- ⁸⁰ Zheng, 'What Is My Role in Changing the System?', 874.
- ⁸¹ Zheng, 'What Is My Role in Changing the System?', 875.
- ⁸² Zheng, 'What Is My Role in Changing the System?', 877.
- ⁸³ Zheng, 'What Is My Role in Changing the System?', 877.
- ⁸⁴ Zheng, 'What Is My Role in Changing the System?', 878.
- ⁸⁵ Zheng, 'What Is My Role in Changing the System?', 882.
- ⁸⁶ I use this example in Maeve McKeown, 'ETMP Discussion of Robin Zheng's "What Is My Role in Changing the System? A New Model of Responsibility for Structural Injustice"', *Pea Soup*, 2018.
- ⁸⁷ For a discussion of complaints being suppressed in the university sector, see Sara Ahmed, *Complaint !* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2021).
- ⁸⁸ Mark Fisher, 'Good for Nothing', in *K-Punk: The Collected and Unpublished Writings of Mark Fisher*, ed. Darren Ambrose (London: Repeater Books, 2018), 749.
- ⁸⁹ Chandra Talpade Mohanty, *Feminism without Borders: Decolonizing Theory, Practicing Solidarity* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2003), 5.
- ⁹⁰ I develop this argument in detail in Maeve McKeown, 'Iris Marion Young's "Social Connection Model" of Responsibility: Clarifying the Meaning of Connection', *Journal of Social Philosophy* 49, no. 3 (2018): 484–502.
- ⁹¹ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 104–13.
- ⁹² Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 112.
- ⁹³ Serena Parekh, 'Getting to the Root of Gender Inequality: Structural Injustice and Political Responsibility', *Hypatia* 26, no. 4 (2011): 681.
- ⁹⁴ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 104.
- ⁹⁵ Kate MacDonald and Christian Barry, 'How Should We Conceive of Individual Consumer Responsibility to Address Labour Injustices?', in *Global Justice and International Labour*, ed. Faina Milman-Sivan, Yossi Dahan and Hanna Lerner (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016), 110; Henning Hahn, 'The Global Consequence of Participatory Responsibility', *Journal of Global Ethics* 5, no. 1 (2009): 49–50. Zheng, 'What Is My Role in Changing the System? A New Model of Responsibility for Structural Injustice', 879.
- ⁹⁶ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 142–7.
- ⁹⁷ Hursthouse and Pettigrove, 'Virtue Ethics'.
- ⁹⁸ G. E. M. Anscombe, 'Modern Moral Philosophy', *Philosophy* 33, no. 124 (1958): 1–19.
- ⁹⁹ Hursthouse and Pettigrove, 'Virtue Ethics'.
- ¹⁰⁰ Julia Annas, 'Being Virtuous and Doing the Right Thing', *Proceedings and Addresses of the American Philosophical Association* 78, no. 2 (2004): 73.
- ¹⁰¹ Hursthouse and Pettigrove, 'Virtue Ethics'.
- ¹⁰² Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 144.
- ¹⁰³ Michael Slote, *From Morality to Virtue* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1995), 121–4.

- ¹⁰⁴ Atkinson, 204; Clive Barnett, Philip Cafaro and Terry Newholm, 'Philosophy and Ethical Consumption', in *The Ethical Consumer*, ed. Rob Harrison Terry Newholm and Deirdre Shaw (London: Sage, 2005), 4–5; Michele Micheletti and Andreas Follesdal, 'Shopping for Human Rights. an Introduction to the Special Issue', *Journal of Consumer Policy* 30, no. 3 (2007): 168.
- ¹⁰⁵ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 118.
- ¹⁰⁶ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 118.
- ¹⁰⁷ Young, 'Responsibility and Global Labor Justice', 384–5.
- ¹⁰⁸ Ronald Dworkin, *Justice for Hedgehogs* (London: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2011), 102.
- ¹⁰⁹ Dworkin, *Justice for Hedgehogs*, 102.
- ¹¹⁰ Dworkin, *Justice for Hedgehogs*, 102.
- ¹¹¹ Mark Bovens, *The Quest for Responsibility: Accountability and Citizenship in Complex Organisations* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), 27.
- ¹¹² Bovens, *The Quest for Responsibility*, 27.
- ¹¹³ Bovens, *The Quest for Responsibility*, 38–9.
- ¹¹⁴ Young, 'Responsibility and Global Labor Justice', 368.
- ¹¹⁵ Young, 'Responsibility and Global Labor Justice', 378.
- ¹¹⁶ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 73.
- ¹¹⁷ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 73–4.
- ¹¹⁸ Robin Zheng, 'What Kind of Responsibility Do We Have for Fighting Injustice? A Moral-Theoretic Perspective on the Social Connections Model', *Critical Horizons* 20, no. 2 (2019): 112.
- ¹¹⁹ Iris Marion Young, 'Responsibility and Global Justice: A Social Connection Model', *Social Philosophy and Policy* 23, no. 1 (2006): 119.
- ¹²⁰ On Derrida and Levinas see Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 118–22. On Larry May see Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 110–11; Young, 'Responsibility and Global Justice', 122; Young, 'Responsibility and Global Labor Justice', 380.
- ¹²¹ Zheng offers an alternative reading: she argues that Youngian political responsibility is grounded in causal contribution to structural injustice, which generates a prospective kind of responsibility as accountability (a kind of remedial responsibility for structural injustice). Such a responsibility does not licence blame, but rather the burden to collectively organize with others. Zheng, 'What Kind of Responsibility Do We Have for Fighting Injustice?'.
- ¹²² Suzanne Duvall Jacobitti, 'The Public, the Private, the Moral: Hannah Arendt and Political Morality', *International Political Science Review* 12, no. 4 (1991): 287; Honig, *Political Theory and the Displacement of Politics*, 84; Arendt, *The Human Condition*, chapters 33–4.
- ¹²³ Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 238.
- ¹²⁴ Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 246.
- ¹²⁵ Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 240.
- ¹²⁶ Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 245.
- ¹²⁷ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 121. My emphasis.
- ¹²⁸ Other theorists have emphasized the necessity of a theory of solidarity to accompany Young's social connection model of responsibility. Ann Ferguson calls this 'transformational solidarity' and Carol Gould 'transnational solidarity.' Ann Ferguson, 'Iris Young, Global Responsibility, and Solidarity', in *Dancing with Iris: The Philosophy of Iris Marion Young*, ed. Ann Ferguson and Mechthild Nagel (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009), 185–99; Carol C. Gould, 'Varieties of Global Responsibility: Social Connection, Human Rights, and Transnational Solidarity', in *Dancing with Iris: The Philosophy of Iris*

Marion Young, ed. Ann Ferguson and Mechthild Nagel (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009), 199–213.

¹²⁹ It could be argued that there is a step prior to cultivating the capacity for solidarity and acting on it, and that is ‘cultivating responsiveness’ to structural injustice in the first place, overcoming the Arendtian thoughtlessness, Sartrean bad faith, or Bourdieusian misrecognition that enables the constant reproduction of structural injustice. I decided not to engage with this problem in this book because I think Jade Schiff has already written an excellent book-length treatment of it, to which I would direct the reader – Jade Larissa Schiff, *Burdens of Political Responsibility: Narrative and the Cultivation of Responsiveness* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016). Also, I suspect that any reader of this book will already be responsive to structural injustice and sensitive to their responsibilities for it. My aim here is not to find a solution to how to generate that responsiveness in others, but rather to focus on the integration of power into an understanding of what structural injustice is and responsibility for it.

¹³⁰ For example, see the edited volume Deen K. Chatterjee, *The Ethics of Assistance: Morality and the Distant Needy* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004).

¹³¹ Angela Y. Davis, *Freedom Is a Constant Struggle: Ferguson, Palestine, and the Foundations of a Movement* (Chicago: Haymarket Books, 2016), 64. For an early statement of this view, see Frederick Douglass, ‘West India Emancipation: Speech Delivered at Canandaigua, New York’, ed. University of Rochester Frederick Douglass Project, 1857, <http://www.lib.rochester.edu/index.cfm?PAGE=4398>. There is also a recent debate in analytic political philosophy about whether victims have a moral duty to resist their oppression, for a helpful summary, see Ashwini Vasanthakumar, ‘Recent Debates on Victims’ Duties to Resist Their Oppression’, *Philosophy Compass* 15, no. 2 (2019): e12648.

¹³² Carol Gould emphasizes this worry with Young’s theory. She acknowledges that Young’s view does not amount to victim-blaming since it is not based on the liability model and that victims do have ‘some residual freedom of choice’, but that including the victims in political responsibility does not take sufficiently seriously the fact of their exploitation and that they lack the power to change the systems. They are coerced into participating and it is ‘unfair’ to include them in political responsibility. Gould, ‘Varieties of Global Responsibility’, 203.

¹³³ Chandra Mohanty, ‘Under Western Eyes: Feminist Scholarship and Colonial Discourses’, *Feminist Review* 30, no. 1 (1988): 66.

¹³⁴ Mohanty, ‘Under Western Eyes: Feminist Scholarship and Colonial Discourses’, 79.

¹³⁵ bell hooks, *Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center* (Boston, MA: South End Press, 1984), 10. See also James C. Scott, *Weapons of the Weak: Everyday Forms of Peasant Resistance* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1987).

¹³⁶ hooks, *Feminist Theory*, 90.

¹³⁷ Amy Allen, ‘Power and the Politics of Difference: Oppression, Empowerment, and Transnational Justice’, *Hypatia* 23, no. 3 (2008): 163.

¹³⁸ Hye-Ryoung Kang, ‘Transnational Women’s Collectivities and Global Justice’, in *Gender and Global Justice*, ed. Alison M Jaggar (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2014), 57.

¹³⁹ Kang, ‘Transnational Women’s Collectivities and Global Justice’, 52.

¹⁴⁰ Allen, ‘Power and the Politics of Difference’, 167.

¹⁴¹ Brooke A. Ackerly, *Just Responsibility: A Human Rights Theory of Global Justice* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018), 184.

¹⁴² Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 105–6.

¹⁴³ Rubén A. Gaztambide-Fernández, ‘Decolonization and the Pedagogy of Solidarity’, *Decolonization: Indigeneity, Education & Society* 1, no. 1 (2021): 49.

¹⁴⁴ Gaztambide-Fernández, ‘Decolonization and the Pedagogy of Solidarity’, 48.

- ¹⁴⁵ Jodi Dean, *Solidarity of Strangers: Feminism After Identity Politics* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1996), 17.
- ¹⁴⁶ Dean, *Solidarity of Strangers*, 18.
- ¹⁴⁷ Dean, *Solidarity of Strangers*, 180.
- ¹⁴⁸ Dean, *Solidarity of Strangers*, 47. Various versions of this thought have emerged in recent literature. Solidarity has been conceived of as relational (Gaztambide-Fernández, 'Decolonization and the Pedagogy of Solidarity'), networked (Carol C. Gould, 'Transnational Solidarities', *Journal of Social Philosophy* 38, no. 1 (2007): 148–64.), 'intersectionality of struggles' (Davis, *Freedom Is a Constant Struggle*, 144), amongst others. The underlying idea throughout is that difference and disagreement are at the root of solidarity.
- ¹⁴⁹ Frantz Fanon, *Black Skin, White Masks* (London: Pluto Press, 2008), 74.
- ¹⁵⁰ Fanon, *Black Skin, White Masks*, 74.
- ¹⁵¹ hooks, *Feminist Theory*, 43.
- ¹⁵² hooks, *Feminist Theory*, 46–7. See also Christopher Lebron, 'Equality from a Human Point of View', *Critical Philosophy of Race* 2, no. 2 (2014): 125–59.
- ¹⁵³ hooks, *Feminist Theory*, 55.
- ¹⁵⁴ hooks, *Feminist Theory*, 15.
- ¹⁵⁵ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 146.
- ¹⁵⁶ Nora Berenstain, 'Epistemic Exploitation', *Ergo* 3, no. 22 (2016): 569–90.
- ¹⁵⁷ Françoise Vergès, *A Decolonial Feminism*, ed. Ashley J. Bohrer (London: Pluto Press, 2021), 26.
- ¹⁵⁸ José Medina, *The Epistemology of Resistance: Gender and Racial Oppression, Epistemic Injustice, and Resistant Imaginations* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), 256–7.
- ¹⁵⁹ Medina, *The Epistemology of Resistance*, 306.
- ¹⁶⁰ Medina, *The Epistemology of Resistance*, 306.
- ¹⁶¹ Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 122.
- ¹⁶² hooks, *Feminist Theory*, 11.
- ¹⁶³ Derrida too recognizes the importance of distance in his conception of political friendship: 'The co-implication of responsibility and respect can be felt at the heart of friendship, one of the enigmas which would stem from this distance, this concern in what concerns the other: a respectful separation seems to distinguish friendship from love.' Jacques Derrida, *The Politics of Friendship* (London: Verso, 2005), 252.
- ¹⁶⁴ Suzanne Duvall Jacobitti, 'The Public, the Private, the Moral: Hannah Arendt and Political Morality', *International Political Science Review* 12, no. 4 (1991): 287.
- ¹⁶⁵ Biskowski, 'Practical Foundations for Political Judgment', 883.
- ¹⁶⁶ Biskowski, 'Practical Foundations for Political Judgment', 883.
- ¹⁶⁷ Canovan, *Hannah Arendt*, 171. Canovan points out that 'Arendt knew from direct experience what it was to be one of "the unfortunate", a member of a persecuted and suffering minority, grateful for authentic *compassion* but infuriated by the patronage of *pity*, and craving the respect *solidarity* implies.'
- ¹⁶⁸ hooks, *Feminist Theory*, 58.
- ¹⁶⁹ Sally J. Scholz, *Political Solidarity* (Pennsylvania: Penn State Press, 2008), 223.
- ¹⁷⁰ Medina, *The Epistemology of Resistance*, 281.
- ¹⁷¹ Ackerly, *Just Responsibility*, 183–5.
- ¹⁷² Nussbaum, 'Foreword', xxi.

- ¹⁷³ Hanna Pickard, 'Responsibility without Blame: Therapy, Philosophy, Law', *Prison Service Journal* 213 (2014): 10.
- ¹⁷⁴ Pickard, 'Responsibility without Blame', 15.
- ¹⁷⁵ Pickard, 'Responsibility without Blame', 12.
- ¹⁷⁶ Pickard, 'Responsibility without Blame', 12.
- ¹⁷⁷ Pickard, 'Responsibility without Blame', 13.
- ¹⁷⁸ Pickard, 'Responsibility without Blame', 14.
- ¹⁷⁹ Pickard, 'Responsibility without Blame', 14.
- ¹⁸⁰ Pickard, 'Responsibility without Blame', 15.
- ¹⁸¹ Pickard, 'Responsibility without Blame', 15.
- ¹⁸² Young, *Responsibility for Justice*, 93.
- ¹⁸³ Pickard, 'Responsibility without Blame', 14.
- ¹⁸⁴ Catherine Lu, *Justice and Reconciliation in World Politics* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017), 259.
- ¹⁸⁵ Robin Zheng, 'Moral Criticism and Structural Injustice', *Mind* 130, no. 518 (2021): 514.
- ¹⁸⁶ Emerick, Barrett, 'Love and Resistance: Moral Solidarity in the Face of Perceptual Failure', *Feminist Philosophical Quarterly* 2, 2016, p. 15 quoted in Zheng, 'Moral Criticism and Structural Injustice', 518.
- ¹⁸⁷ Scholz, *Political Solidarity*, 91.
- ¹⁸⁸ Mohanty, *Feminism without Borders*, 3.
- ¹⁸⁹ Chantal Mouffe, *The Return of the Political*, 2nd edn (London: Verso, 2005), 66.